

The Sensory Walkthrough

A room-by-room audit checklist for your nervous system

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HOW TO USE THIS

This checklist is your starting point.

Before Module 1 drops — before you have your full Sensory Profile Summary — this room-by-room walkthrough gives you something concrete to do right now.

Walk through your home with this in your hand. Check what's working. Note what isn't. Don't try to fix anything yet. The goal right now is observation, not action.

The pile is data. The mess is data. Every room that exhausts you is data.

You're not doing a wrong assessment of your home. You're doing the right one — for the first time.

SCORING KEY

✓ WORKING	✗ NOT WORKING	? UNSURE / NEEDS MORE THOUGHT
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Don't try to fix anything during the walkthrough. Just observe. Bring a pen and mark honestly. Come back to this after Module 1 — you'll see your home differently.

SENSORY WALKTHROUGH

The Entry

The entry is the most important nervous system moment in your home. It is where you transition from the outside world to your inside world — and that transition has a real physiological cost. A poorly designed entry costs spoons before your day has begun.

CHECKLIST

- Is there a designated landing zone — a surface or hook system for bags, keys, coats?

No landing zone = pile. The pile is data.

- Is there adequate storage for the number of people who use this space?

Count coats, shoes, bags, sports gear. If the math doesn't work, the space doesn't work.

- Is the lighting warm and layered, or harsh overhead fluorescent?

The entry lighting is the first sensory signal your home sends.

- Is there a transition moment — a bench to sit and remove shoes, a pause before entering the main space?

Transition moments reduce the physiological cost of switching contexts.

- Is the entry visually calm, or does it present immediate visual chaos?

Your brain processes the entry in 150ms. Make that first impression count.

- Does the entry smell of synthetic fragrance (plug-ins, sprays, candles)?

Synthetic fragrance is a nervous system cost most people don't realize they're paying.

- Is there adequate space to stop and transition, or are you immediately in the main living space?

Buffer zones matter for autistic and ADHD brains — and for anyone carrying a lot.

NOTES FROM THIS ROOM

SENSORY WALKTHROUGH

The Living Room / Main Space

The main living space is where your family regulates together — or fails to. It should support the most sensitive nervous system in the household, not just look good in photos.

CHECKLIST

- Is there at least one area of visual quiet — a surface or wall with nothing on it?

Visual coherence requires some rest for the eye.

- Is the lighting layered (overhead + lamps + task) or single-source overhead only?

Overhead-only lighting is one of the most common nervous system costs in a home.

- Is there a sensory refuge — a corner, chair, or space where someone can regulate without leaving the room?

For autistic and ADHD family members, proximity to others while having a regulation anchor matters enormously.

- Is the acoustic environment manageable — or do sounds bounce off hard surfaces?

Hard floors + bare walls + open ceilings = sensory chaos. Soft furnishings absorb.

- Is there organized complexity (plants, natural textures, layered materials) or visual emptiness?

Brains evolved in natural environments. Organized complexity is regulating; blankness is not.

- Are there enough seating options for different sensory needs (firm vs. soft, upright vs. reclined)?

One type of seating serves one type of body. Sensory diversity needs seating diversity.

- Are children's toys stored in a way that supports both visibility (for ADHD) and containment (for sensory regulation)?

The beige toy debate is real. Organized, bounded, same-zone storage reduces visual load.

NOTES FROM THIS ROOM

SENSORY WALKTHROUGH

The Kitchen

The kitchen is where executive dysfunction meets design failure most visibly. A well-designed kitchen reduces cognitive load before you've turned on a burner. A poorly designed one makes cooking a multi-sensory obstacle course.

CHECKLIST

- Are frequently used items visible and accessible without opening cabinets or searching?

Out of sight = out of mind for ADHD brains. Design your kitchen for your actual memory, not an aspirational one.

- Is there logical adjacency — tools and ingredients stored near where they're used?

Every unnecessary step is an executive function tax.

- Is the lighting adequate for tasks, or are there dark zones and harsh zones?

Kitchens need layered task lighting, not just overhead fixtures.

- Is the kitchen designed for one focused cook, or for a family with children underfoot?

Most kitchens are designed for the former. Most families live the latter.

- Does the space have a designated spot for medications, supplements, or sensory tools your family needs daily?

If it's not built in, it becomes clutter. If it's clutter, it doesn't get used consistently.

- Are surfaces easily cleanable without sensory irritation (strong smells, abrasive textures)?

Cleaning products are a significant sensory variable — design your kitchen for easy maintenance.

- Is there visual quiet somewhere in the kitchen, or is every surface in use at all times?

One clear surface is a nervous system anchor. Design it in deliberately.

NOTES FROM THIS ROOM

SENSORY WALKTHROUGH

The Bedroom(s)

Sleep is the most fundamental physiological regulation tool available to you. The bedroom should do everything possible to support it. This room, more than any other, should be optimized for nervous system repair.

CHECKLIST

- Is the bedding 100% natural fiber — cotton, linen, bamboo?

Synthetic fibers hold heat and can cause tactile dysregulation during sleep. The difference is measurable.

- Can the room be made completely dark?

Blackout is not a preference. For many autistic and ADHD brains, any light source disrupts sleep architecture.

- Is there a source of white noise or sound dampening?

Acoustic sensitivity doesn't stop at bedtime.

- Is the room free of synthetic fragrance — plug-ins, fabric softener residue, strongly scented candles?

Olfactory input continues during sleep. Fragrance-free is not a luxury — it's nervous system maintenance.

- Is the temperature controllable independently from the rest of the home?

Thermal dysregulation is a common autistic and ADHD experience. Bedroom temperature control matters.

- Is visual complexity minimal? Are surfaces clear before sleep?

Visual noise before sleep activates rather than calms the nervous system.

- Is there a wind-down transition space or ritual embedded in the room design?

The transition from awake to sleep is a nervous system task. Design it in.

NOTES FROM THIS ROOM

SENSORY WALKTHROUGH

The Bathroom

Bathrooms are one of the highest sensory-load rooms in the home — lighting, sound, smell, temperature, texture, and time pressure all converge. For many neurodivergent people, the bathroom is the room most likely to be avoided or dreaded.

CHECKLIST

- Is the lighting warm and layered, not single-bulb overhead or cool-white LED?

Bathroom lighting is consistently overlooked and consistently dysregulating.

- Are personal care products fragrance-free or at least fragrance-minimal?

The bathroom concentrates fragrance more than any other room. Worth auditing intentionally.

- Is the acoustic environment manageable — or does the fan, plumbing, or echo create distress?

Autistic people often have particularly strong auditory sensitivities in bathrooms. Sound matters.

- Is the room organized so that items are visible or easily found without searching?

Morning executive function is often lowest. Remove friction from the routine.

- Is there a mechanism for temperature regulation — heated floor, towel warmer, warm lighting?

Cold is a common sensory trigger. Design warmth in.

- Is there a visual anchor — a plant, a simple piece of art, something for the eyes to rest on?

Visual anchors in bathrooms reduce the sense of clinical sterility that many ND people find dysregulating.

NOTES FROM THIS ROOM

SENSORY WALKTHROUGH

Children's Rooms

A neurodivergent child's room should be designed for their nervous system — not for Instagram. This means regulation before aesthetics, always. The most beautiful room is the one your child can actually sleep and exist in.

CHECKLIST

- Is the room visually organized in a way that supports the child's specific clutter profile?
A Visual Processor needs to see their things. A Minimal Regulator needs containment. Know which applies.
- Is there a sensory regulation corner — a tent, beanbag, weighted blanket station, or similar?
A designated regulation space gives the child agency over their own nervous system. This matters enormously.
- Is the lighting warm, dimmable, and controllable by the child?
Lighting control = autonomy over sensory environment.
- Is the room free of synthetic fragrance from plug-ins, candles, or strongly scented cleaning products?
Children's rooms especially.
- Are safety considerations addressed — elopement risk, dangerous object access, window and door security?
For higher-support-needs children, safety design is dignity design. Maximum freedom within a safely bounded space.
- Does the room support the child's interests and identity — not just a generic "kids room" aesthetic?
A space that reflects a child's actual self is a space they want to be in.
- Is the transition to sleep supported by the room design — dark, quiet, temperature-controlled?
Children with ADHD and autism often have significant sleep challenges. The room is a variable you can control.

NOTES FROM THIS ROOM

SENSORY WALKTHROUGH

The Home Office / Workspace

The home office is where executive dysfunction and design failure collide most visibly for ADHD and autistic adults. A workspace designed for a focused neurotypical brain will fight you. A workspace designed for your brain will support you.

CHECKLIST

- Is the workspace visually separated from the rest of the home?

Visual separation reduces context contamination — the sense that you're both at work and at home simultaneously.

- Is the lighting adequate for focused work — warm, layered, and without glare?

Glare and inadequate task lighting are direct executive function costs.

- Are frequently used tools visible and accessible without searching?

Object permanence applies to work tools as much as household objects.

- Is there adequate acoustic isolation or sound management?

Open-plan work environments are consistently dysregulating for autistic and ADHD brains. The home office is your chance to solve this.

- Is the workspace organized by activity type — deep work zone, communication zone, creative zone?

Task-switching is harder with a single undifferentiated workspace.

- Is there a defined start and end to the workspace — a way to signal to your brain that work is beginning or ending?

Transition rituals reduce the cost of context-switching.

NOTES FROM THIS ROOM
